

warm winters and blistering summers? Say \$200 a month for a place close enough to the water to be cooled by sea breezes.

VENEZUELA

If Mexico doesn't agree with you, head farther south. Tiny Costa Rica has a large American community and miles of coastline. Panama offers easy access, fabulous beaches, and perhaps the world's best seafood. And, for the first time in many years, Venezuela is finally affordable.

Decades of oil money have given Venezuela the highest per capita income in Latin America. But, like Mexico, Venezuela has been hammered by tighter money and lower oil prices. The country was forced to devalue in 1985-86, and economists believe more devaluations are on the way. As a result, Venezuela is a bargain for the first time in many years.

Stay away from Caracas, the country's smoggy capital and business center. Land at the big airport there and spend a night or two to relax after the trip. Then head for the warm-water beaches to the east. If you prefer, try the mountains or the great central plateau called the *llanos*.

As soon as oil prices go back up, Venezuela will become expensive again. Take advantage of the window now.

BRAZIL

An American friend who grew up in Brazil maintains that Brazilians are the world's most laid-back people. I don't doubt it. Anything anyone wants to do, as long as it's in good fun, seems all right with the Brazilians. Stroll into a fine restaurant wearing a string bikini, dance on a sidewalk, or play soccer on a downtown street and you may draw a crowd. But no one will ask you to leave.

Brazilians believe their mix of Portuguese and African blood gives them their sensuous, fun-loving attitude. They